

Decay: When a sound grows noticeably softer with time, and finally dies out, it is said to be decaying. This is mostly used in an effect called Echo, where a sound needs to grow softer after every echo.

Decibel: Written as dB, this is a logarithmic measure of the loudness of a sound or power of a signal. The human ear, for instance, hears the faintest whisper at around 1 dB and feels ear-splitting pain at around 130 dB—0 dB is eerie silence to most people (some people have been known to hear the faintest of sounds at -10 dB). For a sound to appear about twice as loud, and increase of about 6 dB is required. Since the dB is a relative measurement, a 3 dB increase in signal sounds like a 50 per cent increase in volume. Say a sound is playing at 3 dB and you increase this to 6 dB, it will sound 50 per cent louder than before, but it's actually double the power being used to produce that sound. Increasing it to 9 dB would make it sound twice as loud as the 3 dB sound, but it is now using four times as much power. It's a little complicated, and you should visit www.prorec.com/prorec/articles.nsf/articles/EA68A9018C905AFB8625675400514576 to get a better understanding of how the decibel is calculated. Warning: mathematics involved!

Echo: This is an effect where a sound repeats itself after a set duration, much like the way your voice echoes in large, empty spaces. In Audacity, a sound is “Echoed” by repeating it after a specified delay and with a *decay* that causes the sound to become softer with each echo.

Equaliser: This is the control that makes specific frequencies louder or softer. For example, with the Windows Media Player equaliser, you can control frequencies ranging between 31 Hz and 16 KHz (the human ear's listening capabilities typically fall between 20 Hz and 20 kHz). Of course, it's not just these specific frequencies that are controlled; the equalizer creates a curve between the frequency controls and modifies all frequencies according to the curve. Equalisers are often needed to tweak the output of speakers in differently-spaced areas (open-air, indoors,